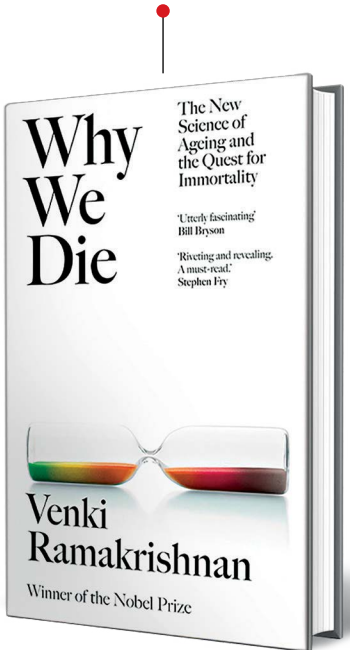
BOOKS

The Life Eternal

THE QUEST FOR IMMORTALITY AND THE SCIENCE BEHIND IT ARE EXPLAINED IN LAYPERSON'S TERMS IN THIS BOOK BY THE NOBEL LAUREATE VENKI RAMAKRISHNAN

WHY WE DIE
The New Science of Ageing and the Quest for Immortality
by Venki Ramakrishnan
HODDER & STOUGHTON
₹699; 320 pages



In the third century BCE, Emperor Qin Shi Huang of China, he of the terracotta army fame, was obsessed with immortality. He sent his men all across the country to look for the "elixir of life". Unfortunately, one such elixir had too much mercury and caused his death. Fast forward to the 21st century and we now have tech billionaires having the same obsession with eternal life.

The average life span of humans, for most of our history, has been quite modest. As late as the 1950s, it was about 45 years, and it is only now that an average human can reasonably hope to live to her seventies. This is mainly due to a phenomenal decrease in infant mortality, enhanced food production due to chemical fertilisers and, of course, modern medicine. However, the human body, like most biological systems, does degrade with age. It is the wear and tear of our body that is the focus of this fascinating new book by the Nobel laureate Venki Ramakrishnan.

At the heart of any biological system is the cell. Hundreds of millions of years of evolution has ensured that this amazing piece of exquisitely fine-tuned machinery functions flawlessly most of the time. Although it has the ability to repair any damages, the chemical damages can reach a point where it starts to malfunction.

The past few decades have seen enormous progress in our understanding of the basic molecular biology of the cell. Dr Ramakrishnan endeavours to make these advances accessible to the lay reader. Crucially, he does not assume any prior knowledge of the subject and explains all the important and relevant aspects. There is understandably a lot of biology in the book, but it is elucidated in simple, easy-to-understand terms. This makes it a rare popular science book which simplifies and yet does not trivialise.

Interspersed in the discussion are short snippets about the men and women who have done so much to increase our knowledge of the subject. His narrative style is extremely reader-friendly and nowhere does one feel intimidated by the huge amount of information in the book. In fact, the book is a delightful read. And for those looking for the secret to a healthy long life, his advice is the usual—moderate, primarily plant-based diet, good sleep and moderate exercise.

Like Qin Shi Huang, the tech billionaires are pouring their millions into finding the "elixir of life". Commenting on their obsession, Dr Ramakrishnan observes that "when they were young, they wanted to be rich and now that they are rich, they want to be young". ■

–Shobhit Mahajan